

NEW HELMSMAN Amit Chavda (centre) takes charge as the Gujarat Congress chief, Jul. 22

GUJARAT

CHAVDA FACES AN UPHILL CHALLENGE

Gujarat Congress, sunk in defeatism after serial losses and desertions, entrusts its future to a young OBC face

promise in 2018-21. In many ways, this reversion expresses the logic the party is now seeking to abide by strictly: going for ideological solidity first of all, and seeking to grow like grass, hugging the ground and spreading horizontally, instead of fostering rootless wonders that fly off at first wind.

Turning a desert into a savannah is an ambitious project, though, for what Chavda faces is a scenario of utter devastation. The mood in the party, just before he took over from Rajya Sabha MP Shaktisinh Gohil in July, condensed all the gloom and frustration of decades. Gohil had resigned after the Congress lost two bypolls in June—one to its bête noire of decades, the BJP; one, embarrassingly enough, to the new challenger, the Aam Aadmi Party. It capped the phase of acute depression that set in after the 2022 assembly election. Unlike the 2017 edition, where it had put up its best show since 1985 with 77 seats and 41.4 per cent of the overall vote, the Congress atrophied miserably: it managed to put only 17 MLAs in a house of 182, less than one-tenth, with a measly 27.2 per cent vote share. Then, it went on to suffer a dramatic shrinkage in even those scanty holdings, plummeting to 12 seats. How? The usual route: five legislators defected to BJP.

THE FIFTH COLUMNISTS

So, to begin with, Chavda has to halt soil erosion and navigate deep credibility crises, as the precondition to a revival ahead of the 2027 assembly poll. The dramatic term '*gaddaar*' (traitor) is often invoked in party meetings, referring to insiders in touch with the BJP, either with the intention of crossing over at the right time or to stay within as pro-BJP saboteurs. Rahul has publicly acknowledged this deep internal mistrust, calling for a purge of those "who work for BJP". This is what has taken the form of a total organisational overhaul, which it calls *sangathan srijan abhiyan*.

This is where Chavda is believed to bring real value. He's seen as wedded to the Congress ideologically, a bond sprung from old family ties, and thus unaffected by the BJP's wooing. His long electoral experience and proven leadership is holding out a sliver of cautious hope to cadres after a long time. If a spurt in optimism seems misplaced, ascribe it to the low base effect: even an entrenched leader like former state unit chief and LoP Arjun Modhwadia had defected to the BJP in 2024.

A BUDDING ANTIPATHY

There's another cause for optimism. "After three decades of the BJP, there's considerable anti-incumbency," says a Congress veteran. "Especially in the last decade, since Narendra Modi became PM, all three chief ministers were seen as ineffective placeholders." The electorate is restless, and the Congress is aware that the need for an alternative is peaking. "Chavda's task is to enable us to occupy that space urgently. AAP is often